‘Suresh!’

‘Usha!’

‘Binya!’

‘It’s me!’

‘It’s us!’

They fell into each other’s arms, so surprised and relieved that all they could do was laugh and **giggle** and repeat each other’s names.

Then Usha said, ‘I thought you were ghosts.’

‘We thought you were a ghost!’ said Suresh.

‘Come back under the roof,’ said Usha.

They **huddled** together in the corner chattering **excitedly**.

‘When it grew dark, we came looking for you,’ said Binya. ‘And then the storm broke.’

‘Shall we run back together?’ asked Usha. ‘I don’t want to stay here any longer.’

‘We’ll have to wait,’ said Binya. ‘The path has fallen away at one place. It won’t be safe in the dark, in all this rain.’



‘Then we may have to wait till morning,’ said Suresh. ‘And I’m feeling hungry!’

The wind and rain continued, and so did the thunder and lightning, but they were not afraid now. They gave each other warmth and confidence. Even the ruins did not seem so forbidding.

After an hour the rain stopped, and although the wind continued to blow, it was now taking the clouds away, so that the thunder grew more distant. Then the wind too moved on, and all was silent. Towards dawn the whistling-thrush began to sing. Its sweet broken notes flooded the rain washed ruins with music.

‘Let’s go,’ said Usha.

‘Come on,’ said Suresh. ‘I’m hungry.’

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